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"Aiding the Greek Rebel Infidels": Insights from the Ottoman Archives on Lord Byron's Missolonghi Mission

Hüseyin Alhas [a] and Yiğit Sümbül [b]

[a]Department of English Language and Literature, Social Sciences University of Ankara, Ankara, Turkey; [b]Department of English Language and Literature, Ankara Haci Bayram Veli University, Ankara, Turkey

ABSTRACT
In contrast to the extensive body of research in European sources on the various political-economic, social-cultural and ethical subtleties of Lord Byron's involvement in the Greek War of Independence, there has been a dearth of studies exploring the Ottoman perspective on the issue. This has stemmed primarily from the fact that Ottoman archival documents on Byron's activities in Greece have so far remained untranslated. This article is the first full-fledged and extended attempt to fill this lacuna where those Ottoman archival documents on Byron are transcribed, translated, and critically interpreted. Taking four intelligence reports from the Ottoman archives as its focal point, this article not only examines the Ottoman Empire's hitherto unsurveyed alertness to Byron's political, economic, and military support to the Greeks, particularly in Missolonghi, but also elucidates the general Ottoman perception of philhellenism.

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Introduction

"I must attend to the Greek cause, both from honour and inclination".[1] Thus speaks Lord Byron, the renowned English poet and nobleman, to express his dedication to the ideal of Greek Independence from the Ottoman Empire in his 29 October 1823 letter, from Greece, to his Italian lover the Countess Guiccioli. Uttered in the months preceding Byron's death on 19 April the following year in Missolonghi, Greece, these words not only highlight the alleged justification for the poet's presence in Greece during those drastic times but also reinforce the Byron myth in Europe built on his revolutionary character as well as his Romantic spirit. The image of Byron as a selfless proponent of the Greek cause is a largely self-crafted one sustained by his numerous poems depicting the struggle of the Greeks under Ottoman rule.[2] Considered in their aesthetic/intellectual

CONTACT Hüseyin Alhas huseyin.alhas@asbu.edu.tr

[1]Byron, *Byron's Letters, Vol. 11*, 57.

[2]Notable among these poems are "Maid of Athens, Ere We Part" (1810), expressing both personal devotion and an homage to Greek language (ll. 6, 12, 18, 24); *Childe Harold's Pilgrimage* (1812), which contemplates the former grandeur of Athens (ll. 693–710); "The Curse of Minerva" (1812), denouncing Lord Elgin's removal of the Parthenon marbles and reflecting Byron's admiration of sacred sites and historical monuments of ancient Greece (ll. 42–50, 55–62); *The Giaour* (1813), set in Ottoman Greece, interweaving evocative descriptions of Greek locales with the plight of its inhabitants (ll. 90–93); and *The Siege of Corinth* (1816), juxtaposing a city of ancient repute with the devastation brought by conflict (ll. 371–378).

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context, the poems in question readily throw into relief the crucial role Byron played in the movement of philhellenism prevalent at the turn of the nineteenth century (see below). However, once taken out of this context of philhellenism, Byron's presence in Greece during the Greek War of Independence assumes strictly political dimensions evidenced by the letters, journal entries and reports written by and/or about him. There has been an extensive body of research on the various political, economic, ethical and cultural subtleties and ramifications of Byron's involvement in the Greek cause as reflected in British and continental European sources. However, in contrast to the plethora of Byron studies based on these Western sources, there has been a dearth of studies exploring the Ottoman perspective on the issue primarily because Ottoman archival documents on Byron's activities in Greece have so far remained untranslated and, hence, un(der)studied. This article is the first full-fledged and extended attempt to fill this lacuna where those Ottoman archival documents are transcribed, translated, and critically interpreted. In so doing, this article not only examines the Ottoman Empire's hitherto unsurveyed alertness to Byron's political, economic, and military support to the Greeks in Missolonghi but also elucidates the general Ottoman perception of philhellenism.[3]

An examination of these archival documents offers a new perspective on Byron's political activism while also illuminating the complex events surrounding the Greek War of Independence. The archival materials provide valuable insights into the multifaceted economic, political, and cultural relationships among various parties, including Byron himself, the British government, the Greek populace, the proponents of Greek independence, and the Ottoman Empire. By exploring these intricate dynamics, the analysis sheds light on the interconnectedness of these actors and the broader implications of their interactions during this tumultuous period.

Byron in Missolonghi

Before analysing these archival sources, it is essential to indicate the significance of Missolonghi, a city of considerable importance in Byron studies that features prominently in historical and literary documents. Undoubtedly, Missolonghi holds great significance as the city where Byron—having channelled his wealth to ignite the Greek cause—stood ready to take up arms and lead his men into battle, and ultimately breathed his last in 1824. His death is commemorated by a cenotaph containing his heart and a statue located in the town. Additionally, Byron's connection to Missolonghi has been immortalised in various renowned artworks within Byron circles. For example, "The House of Christos Kapsalis, Lord Byron's Residence in Messolonghi" (April 1824) portrays the home where Byron and his entourage stayed while strategising their efforts against the Ottomans. Similarly, "The Reception of Lord Byron at Missolonghi" by Theodoros Vryzakis (1861) captures the poet's arrival and the warm welcome he received from the city's residents. These paintings portray the profound connection between the poet and the

[3]It should be noted that this article does not primarily address the Ottoman perspective on the Greek War of Independence. Its focus is instead on Byron's activities and the wider discourse of philhellenism. For a comprehensive analysis of the Ottoman imperial approach to the conflict, including its underlying causes as understood by the Sultan, the impact of rivalries among the Sultan's pashas on the progress of the war, and the escalation of violence against insurgents that ultimately proved counterproductive, see Ozavci, "The Ottoman Imperial Gaze", 222–37. This study provides a distinct and detailed perspective on these issues.

city. Byron indeed played an active role in Missolonghi during the war, which is indicative of his deep philhellenism and unwavering support for the independence movement. His actions in the city demonstrate his commitment to the cause, including leading troops financed mostly out of his own pocket. He was determined to support the actual battle and was willing to participate personally if necessary. This resolve is exemplified in a letter he wrote shortly after arriving in Missolonghi in February 1824: "I take it that a man is on the whole as safe in one place as another—and after all he had better end with a bullet than bark in his body".[4] Byron's deep commitment to the city did not go unrequited as he was given citizenship of the city by its primates for his momentous services.[5] This city, therefore, occupies a crucial place in Byron's life. It epitomises his philhellenism, his multifaceted (military and economic) support for the Greek War of Independence and, ultimately, it is the place of his death. Missolonghi symbolises the culmination of Byron's ideals and actions in support of Greek independence.

The financial assistance Lord Byron provided in the strategic context of Missolonghi was of considerable significance. At the time, the various Greek factions, often led by competing political and military leaders, recognised Byron as a valuable resource, actively seeking his patronage and influence to secure desperately needed funds. His financial support took multiple forms. In addition to his personal loans and contributions, he also functioned as an intermediary, indirectly facilitating aid through English networks, including both state representatives and philanthropic associations. As Brewer has noted, "Byron was in effect the paymaster for the whole Greek war effort which centred on Mesolongi".[6] This observation, while underscoring Byron's substantial financial contribution to the Greek cause, also reflects his understanding that warfare is not solely a matter of military strength or tactical prowess, but fundamentally hinges upon robust financial resources which he refers to, in a letter to Charles Hancock, as "the sinews of war".[7]

It should also be noted that Byron's engagement was closely intertwined with the efforts of the *London Greek Committee*, established in 1823 by liberal Whigs and other prominent supporters of the Greek cause. The committee's primary objectives included raising funds, disseminating information, and securing broader European sympathy for and involvement in the Greek struggle against Ottoman authority. In practical terms, the committee organised financial support, mobilised volunteers, and engaged in public advocacy through meetings and publications. Byron's membership and active involvement greatly enhanced the committee's visibility and legitimacy. His prominence, international reputation, and personal dedication were instrumental in persuading prospective donors and facilitating financial arrangements.

One illustrative example of Byron's extensive financial involvement is found during his sojourn in Italy, prior to his direct participation in the Greek conflict. In a series of correspondences with his friend and banker Douglas Kinnaird, Byron conveyed his urgent need for all available funds—both from his literary earnings and the sale of his property—to be converted into liquid assets usable in the Ionian Islands. By July 1823, Byron had assembled nearly £9,000 sterling for the Greek cause and, in addition,

[4]Byron, *Byron's Letters, Vol. 11*, 107.
[5]Gamba, *A Narrative*, 231.
[6]Brewer, *The Greek War*, 213.
[7]Byron, *Byron's Letters, Vol. 11*, 107.

urged his English associates such as Sir John Bowring to pursue the prospect of raising a more substantial Greek loan on the London market. His financial commitments did not end with this initial capital accumulation. On 13 November 1823, he signed a loan agreement for £4,000 dedicated to the Greek fleet defending Missolonghi. This substantial contribution proved crucial. When Mavrokordhátos, entrusted by the civic and military authorities of Missolonghi to secure its defence, arrived at the city, it was with a fleet funded by Byron's resources.[8]

Upon reaching Missolonghi, Byron endeavoured to influence the course of the war through both strategic and economic measures. His primary objective became the capture of the nearby stronghold at Naupaktos. To this end, he provided support and financial incentives to local brigades and mercenaries, hoping to unify them against Ottoman forces. He agreed to subsidise a contingent of a few hundred Souliots[9] for a year—an arrangement he would later regret due to their undisciplined conduct, constant demands for increased pay, and disruptive behaviour.[10] After the Souliots murdered an officer and threatened to depart for more lucrative opportunities elsewhere, Byron ultimately offered them a month's wages to leave Missolonghi and never return. This incident, among others,[11] highlights the difficulties Byron faced in Missolonghi in attempting to impose order upon disparate military factions motivated as much by personal gain as by patriotic fervour.[12]

Byron's perceived leadership in Missolonghi also drew upon his foreign status and personal prestige. He noted that Greek captains were more amenable to a neutral foreign command than to leadership by any one Greek faction. Byron also believed that this impartiality might facilitate the surrender of Naupaktos and render it simpler to bribe its defenders into capitulation.[13] These assumptions are expressed in his letter to Charles Hancock, dated 5 February 1824, as follows:

> [I]t is the opinion that I should go,—firstly, because they will sooner listen to a foreigner than one of their own people, out of native jealousies: secondly, because the Turks will sooner treat or capitulate (if such occasion should happen) with a Frank than a Greek; and, thirdly, because nobody else seems disposed to take the responsibility. [...] As for me, I am willing to do what I am bidden, and to follow my instructions. I neither seek nor shun that nor any thing else that they may wish me to attempt.[14]

However, Byron's aspirations were frustrated when Yusuf Pasha, the Turkish commander at Patras, discovered certain pro-surrender elements within the Ottoman garrison,

[8]Moore, *Lord Byron*, 393.

[9]Souliots were an Orthodox Christian Albanian tribal community from the Souli region in Epirus, a historical area now divided between Greece and Albania. Renowned for their fierce resistance against Ottoman rule, the Souliots played a pivotal role in the Greek War of Independence. Their expertise in guerrilla warfare made them invaluable allies in the fight for Greek nationhood. However, their strong tribal identities and independent spirit sometimes led to conflicts with other Greek factions and leadership, as evidenced by their undisciplined conduct and eventual departure from Missolonghi.

[10]Byron, *Byron's Letters, Vol. 11*, 31–32; Beaton, *Byron's War*, 214.

[11]Several notable incidents are described in Byron's letter to John Murray dated 25 February 1824: "On Thursday, a quarrel ensued between the Suliotes and the Frank guard at the arsenal: a Swedish officer was killed, and a Suliote severely wounded, and a general fight expected, and with some difficulty prevented. On Friday, the officer was buried; and Captain Parry's English artificers mutinied, under pretence that their lives were in danger, and are for quitting the country". (Byron, *Byron's Letters, Vol. 11*, 124)

[12]Brewer, *The Greek War*, 206–11; Byron, *Byron's Letters, Vol. 11*, 34, 124.

[13]Beaton, *Byron's War*, 215.

[14]Byron, *Byron's Letters, Vol. 11*, 107.

exiled them, and secured additional funds to bolster the fortress's defence. Despite these setbacks, Byron's commitment did not waver.[15] By early 1824, he had sold his Rochdale Manor property for £11,250, a measure that further illustrates the depth of his personal financial investment in the Greek cause. In one letter to Douglas Kinnaird, he remarked that he "should not give the Greeks but a half helping hand"[16], indicating that he felt compelled to offer substantial—though perhaps not unlimited—support in pursuit of Greek independence.

It should also be underlined here that Byron's role in the Greek cause underwent a significant transformation, shifting from financial oversight to active military leadership. In one of his early letters to Douglas Kinnaird, dated 10 December 1823, he writes: "In the mean time I stand paymaster, and what not; and lucky it is that, from the nature of the warfare and of the country, the resources even of an individual can be of partial and temporary service".[17] By referring to himself as a "paymaster," Byron highlights his function in the economic-political sphere. However, in a subsequent letter to Charles Hancock dated 5 February 1824, he states:

> [I]t seems that I am to be Commander-in-Chief, and the post is by no means a sinecure, for we are not what Major Sturgeon calls "a set of the most amicable officers". [However,] between Suliote chiefs, German barons, English volunteers, and adventurers of all nations, we are likely to form as goodly an allied army as ever quarrelled beneath the same banner.[18]

Despite voicing certain doubts about the cohesiveness of his diverse military forces, he nonetheless expresses optimism regarding the potential of this "goodly [...] allied army." Within the brief span of two months, Byron thus progressed from "paymaster" to "Commander-in-Chief" in Missolonghi, indicating his adaptability and dedication to the Greek struggle. Although Byron's military initiative was curtailed by his untimely death from illness on 19 April 1824, before the major battles of the Greek War of Independence, it is still possible to speculate that, in his final days of engagement, he fully assumed the responsibilities of directing military operations up until falling ill. His evolving leadership, ranging from financial support to commanding authority, testifies to his profound commitment to the Greek cause. However, situating them in the general context of the Greek War of Independence, Brewer evaluates Byron's military and political-economic endeavours in Missolonghi as relatively inadequate:

> Byron had spent just over a hundred days in Mesolongi, and in one sense had achieved nothing. He had wanted to use his influence and his money in three spheres: military, political and humanitarian. The military (Návpaktos) and the political (Sálona) initiatives came to nothing and would have had little effect even if they had succeeded. If Návpaktos had surrendered to a force under Byron, no other Turkish stronghold would have fallen as a result. If Byron had gone to the Sálona congress he would not have brought Mavrokordhátos and Odysseus together. Only in the humanitarian sphere was Byron successful, but his rescue of Greeks and Turks impartially, laudable as it was, had no effect on the war.[19]

[15]Brewer, *The Greek War*, 209.
[16]Byron, *Byron: A Self-Portrait*, 199.
[17]Byron, *Byron's Letters, Vol. 11*, 80.
[18]Ibid., 759.
[19]Brewer, *The Greek War*, 219.

While Byron's direct military and political objectives were not realised, his profound financial commitment and moral support to the Greek cause remain significant. His endeavours, even if ultimately unsuccessful in altering the immediate trajectory of the conflict, contributed to the broader narrative of the European philhellenic movement. Through the provision of funds, advocacy via the *London Greek Committee*, and personal intervention, Byron reinforced the international dimension of the Greek struggle for independence, leaving an enduring mark in the cultural perception of this seminal historical event.

The Ottoman Perspective to Byron's Activities in Missolonghi

Turning to the Ottoman archival documents, it becomes evident that these materials present a starkly contrasting perspective. What Byron and his contemporaries viewed as a war of independence was perceived by the Ottomans as a rebellion against an empire that had justly ruled these lands for centuries.[20] Byron's support for what he considered the fight for freedom and the revival of the classical Greek world that contributed so significantly to civilisation was, from the Ottoman standpoint, an undermining of imperial authority and an incitement of subjects to rebellion.[21]

In the Ottoman archives, four extant hand-written documents (three in Ottoman Turkish and one in Greek) offer substantial insight into Lord Byron's involvement in the Greek War of Independence, particularly concerning his financial and military support, the potential motivations for that support, and the political-historical circumstances surrounding his actions.

In the archival document (BOA.HAT.928.40290-D), dated 2 March 1824, the details of Byron's initial arrival and his aims in Missolonghi are indicated as follows:

> To my exalted, kind, gracious, and benevolent master, my Sovereign:
>
> Aside from the fact that the English state is involved in inciting and aiding the Greek rebel infidels, it was twenty days ago that I heard a rumour that one of the English noblemen—a Lord Byron by name—accompanied by two generals and thirty trained artillerymen, as well as a substantial sum of five hundred thousand black coins sourced from one of their great aristocratic houses, had arrived in Missolonghi (Μεσολόγγι). Because I was uncertain as to the truth of this information, I dispatched a special agent towards Missolonghi to investigate the matter. He recently returned and confirmed the facts as previously heard: an English nobleman has indeed come to the town of Missolonghi and currently remains there. The control and management of the docks and agricultural yields of Missolonghi and the

[20]Demirhan, *Büyük Güçlerin Gölgesinde*, 7-16; Ozavci, "The Ottoman Imperial Gaze", 224–31. It should also be noted that, as several studies demonstrate, the rebellion was regarded by the Ottomans as unjust since they believed the Greeks had long been granted religious freedom and were governed under what they perceived as a just administration. From the Ottoman perspective, the insurrection was attributed primarily to Russian interference rather than to the agency of the Greeks themselves. (See Ozavci, "The Ottoman Imperial Gaze", 236). However, Karabıçak's study of archival documents suggests that the Ottomans, while not fully grasping the dynamics of nationalism, were to some extent aware that the movement might contain such elements. (See Karabıçak, "Ottoman Attempts", 318–54). Karabıçak examines Ottoman efforts to categorise and interpret Greek liberation activities and compares these with Ottoman understandings of nations and societies in both ethnic and religious terms.

[21]Turkish historical sources suggest that the Ottoman authorities initially misinterpreted the Greek uprising as a foreign-orchestrated plot rather than recognising it as a legitimate national movement for independence. Upon realising the gravity of the situation and the depth of local support for the revolt, the Empire reassessed its stance and implemented drastic measures to suppress the rebellion (Ozavci, "The Ottoman Imperial Gaze", 224–31).

> Karli-Eli[22] region, along with other resources, have been given to this nobleman. Should the infidels of Karli-Eli comply and remain steadfast in their revolt, he shall provide them with whatever funds, provisions, and munitions they may require. These aforementioned infidels have pledged to proceed accordingly, and have already received large sums of money and provisions from this nobleman named Byron. My reliable informant, the dispatched spy, has confirmed these details. As to what may ultimately come of this, I am myself astonished. Trusting in your wisdom and sovereignty, I have ventured to report these matters to you, my lord.[23]

The content of the archival document in question not only details Byron's arrival in Missolonghi but also underlines the sizeable financial and military support he brought with him—an element that was of immediate concern to Ottoman authorities. In particular, references to the money Byron brought and the mention of "two generals and thirty trained artillerymen" highlight the seriousness of Byron's engagement, as well as the significance of external backing for the Greek insurgents. The tone of the document suggests that the Ottoman official responsible for gathering and relaying this information was alarmed by the scale of Byron's influence. The official's decision to send an agent specifically to verify the rumour underscores the importance attributed to intelligence-gathering within the context of Greek provinces. Upon verification, the threat that Byron posed to Ottoman interests was made explicit: Byron was said to be in command of resources of Missolonghi and the general Karli-Eli region, from which he could provision insurgents. The dispatch further notes that these rebels, in turn, pledged loyalty in exchange for ongoing financial and material support, implying that Byron had the capacity to strengthen both the infrastructure and morale of the insurgent forces.

The document thus reveals critical aspects of the Ottoman response to Byron's arrival in Missolonghi. First, it shows that the Ottoman Empire was not merely aware of Byron's physical presence in the city but also understood his capacity to galvanise the Greek movement through monetary and military channels. Second, the official's expression of astonishment points to the weightiness of this intelligence and the immediate need for the central government's guidance. This suggests that Ottoman authorities perceived Byron's involvement as a substantive threat, one that could have a considerable impact on the Empire's broader efforts to suppress the Greek Revolt. The urgency displayed in this communication indicates the Ottoman Empire's anxieties regarding foreign interference in its internal affairs—particularly one from prominent British figures such as Byron, whose aristocratic status and extensive resources added an international dimension to local insurgencies.

In another Ottoman archival document (BOA.HAT.926.40255), dated 19 January 1824, Byron's undertakings receive much greater attention. This source provides a detailed discussion of his activities, shedding new light on the extent of his influence and the ensuing Ottoman responses. The document reads as follows:

> To my exalted, beneficent, merciful, and gracious lord, my Sovereign:
>
> Reports state that a nobleman named Lord Byron, together with a Colonel named İstanob [Stanhope], both from amongst the English nobility, having brought substantial wealth from European lands, travelled forth from London and, encountering various vagrant groups,

[22]Karli-eli was the name of an Ottoman province in north-western Greece from the late fifteenth century until the Greek War of Independence. It roughly corresponded to the territories of modern-day Acarnania and most of Aetolia.
[23]"İngiltere'nin asileri", 1.

> recruited numerous mercenaries by providing generous allowances. Having arrived in Zenta (Сента/Senta), they then proceeded to Missolonghi, where, by distributing abundant pay, they attracted a multitude of infidels. Thus, they aimed to bolster the Greek rebels' resolve and began preparations to attack the fortresses of İnebahtı (Ναύπακτος/Naupaktos) and Kastelli, gathering and displaying supplies and munitions of war.[24]

The opening section of this Ottoman document illustrates that Ottoman authorities were remarkably aware of Lord Byron's activities, whereabouts, and objectives in Greece, particularly in Missolonghi, during the early months of 1824. The document also shows that they possessed considerable information about Byron's military and financial undertakings. Furthermore, the reference to "Colonel İstanob" can be identified with Colonel Leicester Stanhope, a representative of the London Greek Committee, who has been described to have "contributed [...] energy, determination, and at the start a small injection of cash"[25] to the Greek struggle for independence. Although the document states that Colonel Stanhope arrived together with Byron, the poet's letter to Douglas Kinnard in late 1823 reveals that Stanhope reached Missolonghi on a separate vessel prior to Byron's arrival.[26] Still, Byron's own words confirm that they collaborated closely. As he writes, "I am happy to say that Colonel Leicester Stanhope and myself are acting in perfect harmony together—he is likely to be of great service both to the cause and to the Committee, and is publicly as well as personally a very valuable acquisition to our party on every account".[27]

The Ottoman document likewise underscores that Byron and Stanhope arrived in Missolonghi not only to recruit mercenaries and fortify the Greek forces, but also to channel significant financial resources into the conflict. Indeed, the text specifies that Stanhope brought "substantial wealth from European lands [and] London," thereby indicating that European powers were actively funding the rebellion. In this regard, Byron and Stanhope functioned as conduits for transferring monetary support gathered across Europe into Missolonghi, where it would be directed against the Ottomans. The clarity of the document's statements further demonstrates that the Ottoman authorities were fully aware of the external sources underpinning the uprising, recognising both Byron and Stanhope as key agents in delivering European funds to strengthen the Greek cause. Additionally, the use of expressions such as "Greek rebels" in the document emphasises that, from the Ottoman viewpoint, the outbreak in Missolonghi was a rebellion rather than a war of independence. In contrast, from Byron's and the philhellenic perspective, the Greek cause was cast in terms of liberty and emancipation. As such, this Ottoman record serves as a valuable primary source for understanding how different parties perceived the same events conflictingly: while Byron's correspondence reflects a heroic struggle for Greek independence, Ottoman bureaucratic communications characterise the conflict as one of subversion and sedition.

In the next section of the same archival document (BOA.HAT.926.40255), the text provides illuminating details of the Ottoman endeavour to thwart Byron's and the Greek forces' attempts to recruit mercenaries and capture Naupaktos:

[24]"Lord Byron ile bir İngiliz miralayı", 1.
[25]Beaton, *Byron's War*, 220.
[26]Byron, *Byron's Letters, Vol. 11*, 80.
[27]Byron, *Byron's Letters, Vol. 10*, 83.

> Meanwhile, the condition of the Gördes[28] forces on our side, especially the troops stationed in İnebahtı who are demanding their pay, has deteriorated significantly. Their crude and harsh demeanour, along with the obscene and irritating language and behaviour that I cannot detail here, and the disturbing slander have reached a very serious level. If a sufficient amount of money to satisfy and calm them does not arrive within a month, we will find ourselves in a very difficult situation on these fronts. Previously, I informed the imperial court through a special messenger of the deplorable condition of these troops. As their situation without pay has grown unbearable, and it is well-known that I have no funds at hand, if—God forbid—they become emboldened by their grievances and dare to commit betrayal, it is evident that no good will remain on this side. Therefore, to prevent greater harm, it is paramount to suppress corruption. As a temporary remedy, I pledged that on my responsibility seven hundred and fifty purses of coins would be paid within sixty-one days and the remainder of their allowances within one hundred and twenty-one days. Furthermore, until their full wages are paid, I promised to issue fresh pay orders and daily sustenance allowances. Yet, they were not satisfied with this arrangement, and new difficulties arose. Additionally, one of the notables from Feres, Hacı Emin Agha, an appointee from the Imperial Gate, charged with protecting the two aforementioned fortresses, has for some time deviated from propriety and uprightness, leaning instead towards sedition. Although I have tried to admonish him with due care, he has not heeded advice. His misconduct has emboldened these troops. Previously, the same soldiers collectively seized the upper fortress of İnebahtı and Kastel Fortress[29] and openly declared that if their full pay was not provided within ten days, they would "do what they would do," openly threatening rebellion and treason. The few remaining inhabitants of İnebahtı, alongside several elders and deputies, came pleading and crying out for help. Likewise, Islam Bey, one of the deputies of Palaslı İsmail Pasha, and other local notables arrived lamenting and imploring. They stressed that if no remedy is found and no proper order established, the four fortresses and the Muslims within, who are currently guarded with difficulty, will undoubtedly be exposed to grave danger. To calm these soldiers, I dispatched my armourer and footman, along with a few of my officers experienced in dealing with such forces, to negotiate and restore order. Although it has emerged that these troops, having defended the fortress for over three years at the risk of their lives, have unpaid wages exceeding two thousand purses of coins, leaving them severely distressed, and that Hacı Emin Agha's malicious inclinations have only worsened the situation, the soldiers claim that should they receive their pay, not only would they refuse to surrender the fortress to the infidels, but they would fight bravely until none remain, defending with their lives. However, if their pay does not arrive, they assert that they will be powerless to prevent their mercenary troops from betraying us.[30]

As previously discussed briefly, the issue regarding Naupaktos fortress was quite complex. Byron, upon learning that many soldiers charged with defending the castle and the surrounding region on behalf of the Ottoman Empire had not received their wages, sought to bribe them. In doing so, he hoped to secure Naupaktos through financial rather than strictly military means.[31] The document under consideration reveals that Ottoman authorities were clearly aware of Byron's approach and endeavoured to devise strategies to counter it. Although partial payments were provided to some of the unpaid troops, the text emphasises the urgent need for additional resources from the Imperial capital. Such funds were deemed necessary for a decisive response to Byron's monetary inducements. Moreover, the document underscores the efficacy of

[28]Gördes is a district located in Manisa Province, Türkiye.
[29]The Kastel Fortress is a historic stronghold situated in Banja Luka, Bosnia and Herzegovina.
[30]"Lord Byron ile bir İngiliz miralayı", 1.
[31]Beaton, *Byron's War*, 229.

Byron′s methods: even though certain sums were eventually distributed, dissatisfaction lingered among the soldiers, and Hacı Emin Agha had reportedly been swayed towards sedition by these financial overtures. Thus, the Ottoman local authority recognised that if a substantive solution was not found, Naupaktos risked surrendering under the weight of Byron′s bribes. This situation can be likened to a strategic game of chess in which Byron, the Greeks, and the Ottomans each sought to exploit any perceived weakness in the other side′s defences. Against the backdrop of Missolonghi and the defence of Naupaktos, the Ottoman forces found themselves compelled to respond swiftly and effectively, lest the fortress be subjugated through financial means. This part of the document, therefore, provides a critical insight into the multifaceted nature of warfare during this period, illustrating the significance of economic pressures within the broader conduct of military operations. It also demonstrates how Byron′s activities in Missolonghi engendered considerable difficulties for the Ottoman Empire, obliging it to respond with increased urgency.

In the remainder of the same archival document (BOA.HAT.926.40255), the text reveals additional layers of complexity in the Ottoman response to the Greek rebellion and Byron′s involvement:

> While reviewing accounts, it became clear that the calculations and methods of Hacı Emin Ağa and his men contradict all proper standards, prompting fears that he aims to secure his own safety by winning over a segment of the soldiers and causing further discord. Although no final solution has yet been determined as of the date of this report, my envoys are currently present in İnebahtı, attempting to reach a suitable resolution and forestall harm. Whatever resolution is achieved will be promptly reported to your exalted court. Through repeated experience, it has become known that certain protected foreigners, whose reliability has been proven, periodically appear covertly, identified by predetermined signs, and bring news of world affairs and impending events. It is such an informant who, this time as well, has secretly conveyed the appended translated information. According to these reports, Lord Byron and Colonel İstanop, having arrived in Missolonghi with ample funds, have raised five hundred mercenary infidels by offering generous pay, and, supported by war materiel, skilled artillerymen, and disciplined soldiers from Europe, are uniting with other infidels gradually assembling in Missolonghi. Their plan, on a given evening, is to depart Missolonghi and be in a state of readiness by morning to attack the fortresses of İnebahtı and Kastelli. It seems they have made arrangements with some of the soldiers stationed inside İnebahtı fortress and have decided upon a certain route. Furthermore, it is said that a British ship will be positioned to assist at the time of the assault, supplying artillery and munitions. Although the authenticity of these details cannot be fully guaranteed, since similar information has reached us from multiple sources, and considering the unrest among the troops and the loss of our confidence, we must remain vigilant. Drawing lessons from the incident at Tripoliçe (Τριπολιτσάς/Tripolitsa), we must be prepared night and day, exercising prudence and caution. If, God forbid, these rumours prove true, then trusting in the Almighty, we shall maintain fortitude and persevere in our defence. Though the situation is exceedingly challenging, with the spiritual assistance of the Prophet′s intercession and the blessings of the Sultan′s prayers, we aspire to achieve victory. Nonetheless, we are in urgent need of swift and potent guidance from your exalted wisdom. Hence, with humility and devotion, I have composed this petition and dispatched it via my special courier in utmost haste to your exalted threshold. Inshallah, upon its arrival, you shall graciously decree the necessary commands. Your word and order, my sovereign, shall prevail.[32]

[32]"Lord Byron ile bir İngiliz miralayı", 1.

These concluding remarks delve deeper into the prevailing uncertainties within the garrison, highlighting both the internal discord stemming from Hacı Emin Agha's alleged misconduct and the external threats posed by Byron's sustained financial and military interventions. Reports of a British vessel supplying additional war materiel and artillery underscore the increasingly international scope of the conflict. Simultaneously, the potential for some Ottoman soldiers within the fortress to collaborate with the enemy emphasises the significant influence of economic incentives.

Strikingly, the document's appeals for vigilance are complemented by references to the lessons learned from the "incident at Tripolitsa," which is most likely an allusion to the Tripolitsa massacre of 1821. During this atrocity, approximately 10,000 Turkish and Albanian Muslim civilians and Jews were massacred, alongside around 10,000 Turkish soldiers. This is recognised as one of the most brutal and atrocious events of its time.[33] Politically, the fall of Tripolitsa represented a significant loss for the Ottoman Empire, as it was the administrative centre in the Peloponnese. However, the human losses and atrocities had an even more profound impact, leaving an enduring memory of one of the Ottoman Empire's greatest tragedies in the Balkans.

The informant's reference to Tripolitsa thus underscores the severity of the current situation and the potential for significant future tragedies. This reference serves as a compelling plea for prompt assistance and imperial guidance, illustrating the precarious state of affairs in Naupaktos. From a historical perspective, the multifaceted concerns expressed—ranging from potential sedition within Ottoman ranks to covert European support—highlight the complexity of conducting warfare under financial and diplomatic pressures. The reliance on anonymous yet trusted informants further indicates the lengths to which authorities had to go to monitor threats on multiple fronts. By emphasising the urgent need for decisive policies from the imperial centre, the document brings to light the empire-wide implications of events in and around Naupaktos. It suggests that any efforts to counteract Byron's influence required not only local vigilance but also swift and authoritative support from the highest levels of government.

The third Ottoman archival document (BOA.926.40255-E) features intelligence written in Greek language and addressed to the previously mentioned Yusuf Pasha, the Turkish commander at Patras. The document in question reads as follow:

> To His Excellency Vizier Muhlis Yusuf Pasha, the Governor of Aydın and Saruhan Provinces.
>
> What is conveyed here has been confirmed.
>
> Lord Byron and Colonel Stanhope, two English noblemen, are currently in Missolonghi and, together with the notables of the city, have decided to organise an attack on Naupaktos. It is known that Lord Byron has brought a large sum of money on his person and, using this money, he has recruited around five hundred Souliots in the countryside. Apart from these, there are also other English officials and Germans in Missolonghi. These officials and Souliots are prepared to attack Naupaktos under Lord Byron's command. It seems that Lord Byron has also made an agreement with the Albanians in Naupaktos so that they will join the attack, which is to begin at dawn, from within the city. The captain of a British Imperial ship has also been sent to Missolonghi and this captain has already contacted Lord Byron and pledged to be present at the attack in Naupaktos.

[33]St Clair, *That Greece*, 1; Ozavci, "The Ottoman Imperial Gaze", 228.

> Lord Byron is currently waiting for the arrival of an English ship named Anna equipped with cannons and munitions, and some officials in Missolonghi.[34]

Interestingly, the fourth archival document (BOA.926.40255-D) is actually based on the above third archival document addressed to Yusuf Pasha (BOA.926.40255-E). It appears that upon receiving the intelligence from his Greek informant, the Pasha writes to the imperial centre, affirming that the information provided by this informant has been scrutinised and confirmed:

> As recorded in my servant's report, and as indicated therein, this is the translation of a Rūmī-language intelligence, identified by certain known markings, and brought by a protected foreigner whose reliability in conveying accurate news has been tested and confirmed.[35]

Later, in the opening section of the same document, Yusuf Pasha—sharing the informant's intelligence—reports Byron's arrival and details the financial and military support he extended to the rebellion:

> It is widely known that an English nobleman, Lord Byron, and a Colonel named "İstanob," having arrived in Missolonghi, have dispatched substantial funds and granted allowances to five hundred mercenaries, composed of Englishmen, Germans, and other infidels of varied origins so that this band might assemble in Missolonghi. They have thus formed an alliance with the infidels located there in order to advance on and attack İnebahtı. It appears that the aforementioned lord [Byron] has conferred with the Albanians stationed in the fortress at İnebahtı, and it is reported that all the infidels under the lord's command have agreed to set out from their rendezvous point and launch their attack at sunrise. Furthermore, a British brig's captain has arrived in Missolonghi and, after meeting and consulting with the lord, resolved to attack İnebahtı, pledging to render assistance during the assault. According to reliable written accounts, it is established that the aforementioned lord awaits the arrival of a British brig carrying artillery and munitions, all to support the planned offensive.[36]

As with the first two archival documents discussed above, this text demonstrates the breadth of Byron's engagement in orchestrating both financial and military support for the insurgents, thereby highlighting the scope and ambition of his activities. It further illustrates the rising anxiety among Ottoman authorities, who recognised the arrival of allied forces and supplementary munitions—especially via a British brig—as a significant menace.

What renders this document particularly noteworthy, however, is not merely its information regarding Byron but rather its concluding section, where Yusuf Pasha offers a remarkable commentary on philhellenism as a cultural force that gave momentum to the support for the Greek Rebellion. It states:

> All the nations of Christendom, considered branches of the original Greek people, have, since ancient times, produced notable philosophers, sages, and masters of rational sciences and the arts—those famed for their erudition and inventive industriousness, known collectively by the name "Ilyana." Because the Greek nation originally gave rise to renowned scholars and skilled practitioners of various arts, generation after generation, individuals from European lands have hurried to acquire knowledge of medicine, philosophy, printing,

[34]"Mesolongi'ye gelen İngiliz şairi", 1–2.
[35]"İngiltereli meşhur şair", 1.
[36]Ibid.

> and other sciences. Following the legacy of the ancient philosophers, these individuals have styled themselves as "philhellenes," or lovers of Greek philosophy. Presently, in every great dominion of the European lands, there are numerous diligent Greeks engaged in these fields. Many such capable individuals, out of respect for the ancient illustrious reputation of the Greek nation, consider the sacrifice of their wealth and even their lives an honourable investment and source of pride.
>
> Hence, the fact that the lord and the colonel who arrived in Missolonghi have given funds and supported the Greek rebels serves as evidence. Moreover, God forbid, should the Greek rebels not be subdued within a few months of this blessed year, it is likely that many more philhellenes of similar nature will arrive from Europe to aid the rebels by every means. Indeed, at present, many such persons stand ready in various places. In particular, several wealthy noblemen in Geneva have employed substantial resources to procure artillery, munitions, and experts skilled in the arts of warfare, making themselves ready to depart for these lands at any moment. All this information has reached us through a protected foreigner, who is well-informed about world affairs, enjoys esteem within England, and who has covertly conveyed these details verbally through a trusted intermediary. In accordance with the meaning of the noble Prophetic hadith "El küfrü milletün vahide" ("Disbelievers are one nation"), and since the authenticity of these reports is reliable and beyond doubt, the statements have been clarified word-for-word and appended herein as a translation.[37]

This passage provides an unusually candid insight into Ottoman perceptions of the cultural and ideological factors propelling European support for the Greek Rebellion. By drawing attention to the philosophical, scientific, and artistic lineage originating in "the original Greek people" and pervading "all the nations of Christendom," the text underscores a firmly established esteem for classical Greek heritage whilst simultaneously hinting at the danger it poses to the Ottoman Empire. By evoking both the ancient philosophers and modern philhellenes, the document signals that many Europeans—whether of noble or humble origin—felt a profound moral imperative to defend Greek people whose heritage had indelibly shaped Western cultural and intellectual history. Hence, it is evident that Yusuf Pasha fully grasped the deeper historical and cultural foundations of philhellenism that prompted European powers to support the Greeks against the Ottoman Empire.

Underpinned by a fascination with Ancient Greek culture and the desire to revive it in modern times—extending to the political (and sometimes military) aim of freeing Greece from domination—philhellenism indeed appealed to numerous European intellectuals, especially free-spirited Romantic poets in England, such as Lord Byron, Percy Bysshe Shelley, and Leigh Hunt, as well as other European thinkers.[38] This phenomenon was reinforced by a shared Romantic ethos that extolled individual liberty, national liberation, and the reawakening of antiquity's cultural foundations. In this respect, Yusuf Pasha's observations here are both lucid and revealing in their accuracy as the zeitgeist of philhellenism indeed dominated the era. For instance, Percy Bysshe Shelley, a significant advocate of Greek independence, eloquently expressed this abiding belief in the Greek legacy in the preface to *Hellas* (1822), asserting: "We are all Greeks. Our laws, our literature, our religion, our arts have their root in Greece".[39] This concise statement

[37]Ibid.
[38]St Clair, *That Greece*, 164–5.
[39]Shelley, *Hellas*, viii.

captures the essence of the philhellenic fervour typical of the time. Likewise, the *London Greek Committee*, which provided crucial financial and military support for Greek independence, was also known as the *London Philhellenic Committee*, thereby underscoring the depth of its devotion to Greek civilisation and ideals. It should also be underlined here that without question, Byron's endeavours in Greece against the Ottomans—which ultimately brought about his demise—rested upon his enduring admiration for Ancient Greece.[40] Recognised as a committed philhellene, Byron expressed his admiration of and commitment to Greek culture and history, once remarking, "Despite of every yoke she bears, / That land is glory's still, and theirs".[41]

Hence, the document underscores the sense of urgency with which Ottoman officials viewed the escalating threat of philhellenism. It clearly demonstrates that the Pasha recognised how quickly European sympathy could translate into tangible military and financial aid for the Greek cause. By citing "several wealthy noblemen in Geneva" who were amassing artillery, munitions, and combat experts, the text shows that elements of the European elite—fuelled by an idealised admiration for Ancient Greek civilisation—were fully prepared to intervene. This observation not only indicates the Pasha's awareness of immediate dangers but also highlights the far-reaching capacity of philhellenism to rally diverse European communities in support of the rebels. Indeed, as the document affirms, philhellenism, as discussed above, was notably influential in Europe at that time. A widespread fascination with classical Greece had the power to unite people across the continent, many of whom were willing to provide financial and other assistance. In warning that the rebellion's continuation would likely invite intensified European involvement, the Pasha emphasised the growing vulnerability of the Ottoman Empire in the region.

In the final portion of this fourth archival document (BOA.926.40255-D), a marginal note relays intelligence gathered from a Muslim prisoner who managed to escape captivity under Greek forces:

> Among the Muslim prisoners held by the infidels, the son of the clerk of the Kalavorta district court succeeded in escaping and arriving here. When questioned about the conduct and activities of the Morean infidels, he stated that they have not provided any visible supplies to the fortresses of Anabolu (Nafplion) and Gördes. He further reported that thus far they have removed nine crates of artillery pieces from Anabolu, and that from Anabolu and Gördes they have continually extracted and sold gunpowder. He mentioned that a lord [Byron] has arrived in Missolonghi, and that preparations are underway to attack the fortresses of İnebahtı and Kastelli. Several vessels have come from Çamalça and Sulica, blocking the Badre Gulf, hindering any ship from passing by sea. At the same time, the lord plans to advance against the fortresses of İnebahtı and Kastelli by land. In order to prevent any reinforcements from reaching these fortresses from Narda, a group of Morean infidels

[40]It is important to note that there are divergent assessments of Byron's attitude towards Ancient Greece, particularly after his experiences in Greece. Although Byron repeatedly expressed admiration for Ancient Greece in both his poetry and prose, Beaton notes that Byron told Lady Blessington in Genoa that antiquities held no appeal for him and that he doubted their capacity to inspire genuine interest in anyone, a remark he would reiterate in subsequent letters. (Beaton, *Byron's War*, 137) While this apparent inconsistency should be acknowledged, it must also be recognised that individual perspectives can evolve over time and may at times produce seemingly contradictory reflections on the same subject. What is of particular relevance to the present discussion, however, is that the initial impulse drawing Byron to Greece was deeply characterised by philhellenic sentiment. Our argument is therefore grounded on this point.

[41]Byron, *The Siege of Corinth*, 27–8.

> intends to move against Narda. He also indicated that the infidels are now gathering provisions to supply those who will proceed towards Narda.[42]

This marginal note is particularly valuable for understanding how Ottoman authorities gathered front-line intelligence to convey to the imperial centre. The prisoner's testimony offers a rare glimpse into Greek logistical and strategic planning, describing the distribution and sale of artillery pieces and gunpowder from Anabolu and Gördes, as well as the stationing of vessels in the Badre Gulf to hamper maritime traffic. The mention of Lord Byron in connection with forthcoming operations against the fortresses at Naupaktos and Kastelli underlines his continued influence in shaping the Greek war effort. Furthermore, the note underscores the Greeks' multifaceted approach: while Byron organises a land offensive, other forces aim to block potential Ottoman reinforcements from Narda.

Taken together, this first-hand account highlights the practical significance of intelligence derived from recent captives, whose fresh observations could prove critical for Ottoman strategic responses. The Pasha's inclusion of every detail—ranging from artillery transport to maritime blockades—demonstrates the importance of ensuring that the imperial centre remained fully apprised of enemy manoeuvres. By compiling and forwarding such intelligence, local Ottoman commanders sought to mitigate the threat posed by coordinated Greek operations, especially when augmented by European support under figures like Byron. Ultimately, this section of the document reinforces the notion that information from active field sources was integral to Ottoman war planning, as it helped shape responses on both the military and administrative fronts.

Conclusion

Thus, the Ottoman archival materials examined here cast new light on Lord Byron's Missolonghi mission by capturing the Empire's concerns over his substantial military and financial support for the Greek cause. These documents highlight Byron's strategic focus on Naupaktos, his success in swaying both local forces and mercenaries, and the ways in which his endeavours, backed by European funds, complicated Ottoman efforts to suppress the revolt. They also illustrate how Ottoman officials recognised the accelerating threat of philhellenism, perceiving it not merely as intellectual admiration for classical Greek heritage but as an active driving force of European intervention in the Empire's domains. Notably, the records reveal that the Ottomans were well aware of Byron's attempts to capitalise on the turmoil within their ranks—attempts made possible by the significant sums he invested and his fascination with Ancient Greek civilisation.

By weaving together these Ottoman documents with Byron's letters, the activities of the *London Greek Committee*, and the broader cultural ideals of Romanticism, it is indeed possible to discern the intricate web of military, financial, and ideological forces at play in the Greek War of Independence. Byron's fervent commitment, underscored by his leadership in Missolonghi and his personal financial sacrifices, emerges as more than mere idealism; rather, it was a tangible threat from the Ottoman viewpoint,

[42] "İngiltereli meşhur şair", 1.

particularly when coupled with growing philhellenic sentiment across Europe. These findings ultimately enrich the perception of Byron's role, recasting him not only as a Romantic poet-hero but also as an actor deeply enmeshed in the shifting political and cultural landscape of the early nineteenth century. Moreover, these archival insights reveal that a pivotal historical moment—like the Greek struggle for independence—resists confinement to any single lens. Its drama resonates through an array of voices, each weaving its own tapestry of conflict, aspiration, and consequence. Embracing diverse vantage points deepens the narrative, illuminating truths that echo far beyond the boundaries of recorded/single history.

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ORCID

Hüseyin Alhas http://orcid.org/0000-0002-4615-7797
Yiğit Sümbül http://orcid.org/0000-0001-8821-4887

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"İngiltereli meşhur şair Lord Byron'un bir miralay ile Mesolongi'ye gelip Rumları isyana teşvik ve paraca yardım yaptığına ve Mora vukuatına dair" ("Regarding the fact that the famous English poet Lord Byron came to Missolonghi with a colonel, encouraged the Greeks to rebellion, provided financial assistance, and the Mora incident"). Presidency of the Republic of Türkiye, General Directorate of State Archives. BOA.926.40255-D. (25 August 1824). Accessed 20 October 2024.

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